

idea is to deliberately keep wearers aware of their surroundings, since runners run on streets and are prone to accidents.

Testing speakers

Regular speakers: Contrary to what anyone will say, the best way to listen to music is on a stereo speaker system. All your 5.1 / surround are good for movies and explosions, however, for music it's always stereo. So, either a 2.1 channel speaker system (with a sub-woofer) or good old 2.0 bookshelf speakers should be your focus. For a long time (until consumers smartened up), the trend was to

large, these days is within arms reach of any one, except for really high-end SKUs from premium brands. Features such as USB charging and daisy chaining are very useful, and you should keep an eye out for those.

What can you do at the store?

Not much to be honest because of mainly one reason – if you're buying headphones, especially the in-ear variety, chances are you won't really get "open" pieces to demo. If you're in the market for speakers, you're in luck and demos might



A 2.1 speaker set with a control pod

display power rating of speakers in PMPO. In fact, for bundled home theatres it still is. Don't go by this figure as it's highly exaggerated. Instead, go by the RMS rating. A speaker system with an RMS value of 80 watts or more should be loud enough for a mid-size room. Speakers these days also try to bundle plenty of features. Some may be useful such as an FM tuner (debatable) while some like SD card playback seem anachronistic in today's day and age. Seriously, when was the last time you played back any music from an SD card? Even if you want to play music from your phone, you'd probably just insert it into the AUX-in via a standard 3.5mm cable. A control pod for volume, bass and treble is a useful feature. So is bluetooth connectivity.

Portable: The most important thing that differentiates portable speakers from one another isn't sound quality sadly, but the features list. Sound quality, by and

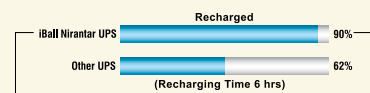
not be out of the question. But remember: at most electronics shops, the audio that the sales staff plays for you may not present an accurate picture of your preferences. Take sample tracks with you. But which tracks? Take your favourite music along. Music you're familiar with or have listened to on decent headphones/speakers will help form at least some reference point. Ensure that the tracks are high bit rate – at least 320 kbps. This will give you an idea about whether the speakers sound good for your genre of choice. However, this is still not good enough to know whether the speakers play back all frequency ranges properly. For this, download sweeps and different frequency tones. One such source is NuForce (<https://goo.gl/g6RYdu>). Carry these in a pen drive fully uncompressed or in different file formats, or better yet burn a .cda album. **f**



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